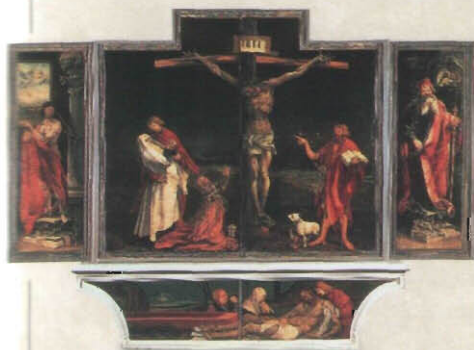


GERMANY, HISTORY OF



ALTHOUGH THERE HAVE ALWAYS been German speakers living in Europe, a single German country did not exist until 1871. For much of its history, Germany consisted of many

small kingdoms, duchies, and other states, kept apart by rivalries. Unification was eventually achieved under the diplomatic and military leadership of the north German state of Prussia. German industrial strength allowed the new nation to dominate Europe, but defeat in two world wars left the country divided again. In 1990, Germany reunited, and once more became the major economic power of Europe.



Isenheim Altarpiece, by Matthias Grünewald

German Renaissance

In the 15th century, the Renaissance spread to Germany. Artists such as Albrecht Dürer (1471–1528) perfected the technique of the woodcut, Hans Holbein (1498–1543), working mostly in Switzerland and England, produced superb portraits, and Matthias Grünewald (1480–1528) painted religious masterpieces.

Peasants' War

In the 16th century, there was much tension between Catholics and Protestants in Germany. In 1524, peasants in southern Germany exploited the confusion to rise up and demand social reforms. The revolt was crushed in 1526.



Peasant rebellion in southern Germany

Seal of Hamburg

Hanseatic League

The cities of northern Germany worked together to support their trading interests. In 1241, Lübeck and Hamburg concluded a treaty that led to the growth of the Hanseatic League, a trading alliance that dominated commerce in northern Europe. At its height there were 160 cities in the League.



Brooch made by Germanic Lombard tribe

Medieval Germany

In 962, Otto I of Saxony united the German kingdoms in the Holy Roman Empire. This empire was long-lasting but weak, as local rulers fought to protect and increase their own power. Despite this disunity, the country became increasingly rich. By the late 15th century, German cities such as Augsburg controlled European banking and finance.



Ulm cathedral

Coming of Christianity

From the 5th century onwards, individual Germans became Christian. Some churches, such as Ulm Cathedral, were founded in the early 7th century, but it was not until the mission of St Boniface in the early 8th century that most of the people converted to Christianity.

Thirty Years' War

In 1618, a revolt broke out in the Protestant province of Bohemia against the rule of the Catholic Habsburgs. War spread through Germany as Protestant princes rebelled against the Habsburgs. Other nations, notably France and Sweden, entered the war on the Protestant side to end Habsburg domination of Europe.

Prussian
by 1648
Prussian
by 1772



Prussian lands in Europe

Rise of Prussia

Prussia was one of the few German states to emerge from the Thirty Years' War with increased power. Under successive rulers, Prussian territory expanded across most of northern Germany and, by 1795, also included western Poland.



Frederick the Great

Frederick, King of Prussia from 1740–86, laid the foundations of later Prussian greatness. An inspired military leader, his diplomacy enabled Prussia to expand by outwitting Austria and Russia. At his death, Prussia was Europe's foremost power.

Treaties of Westphalia

When the treaties ended the Thirty Years' War in 1648, German agriculture and commerce were in ruins, and the population had been reduced by half. The Habsburgs were seriously weakened by the years of conflict and Germany was more disunited than ever before, split into no fewer than 234 states and 51 independent cities.

German rapier of the 1630s



Inscription says that the owner "Fights for God".